

Sedona Police Department begins strategic plan 17 min read

By **Christopher Fox Graham** - March 31, 2026



3-month assessment reviews staffing, officer training

The Sedona Police Department has hired a national consulting firm to conduct what Police Chief Stephanie Foley describes as SPD's first strategic plan — a three-month assessment that will examine staffing levels and patrol coverage to department policy, training programs and long-term succession planning for the future.

The Center for Public Safety Management, a Washington, D.C.-based consulting firm that has worked with fire and law enforcement agencies across Arizona and the West Coast, will conduct the review and consulting work, which is not to exceed \$37,500.

The process will include analysis of information SPD has already submitted, remote and on-site workshops, one-on-one interviews with police officers, dispatchers, commanders and support staff. Sedona City Manager Anette

Spickard said the city will hold a town hall-type meeting for the public about the plan likely Thursday, April 16, or Friday, April 17.

The consultant’s review and results, anonymized data and report will also be made public when the final plan is complete, Spickard said.

Foley said the timing was deliberate, coming after hiring, structural changes and new programs.

“We’ve had a lot of positions added. We’ve changed structures. We’ve gone through a lot,” she said. “We’ve been on a path, but we really haven’t done anything that’s been strategic planning. We’ve done a lot of goal setting, but nothing that really outlines how to get there in a matrix. So before we start making any additional changes, it’s a good time to do a check in.”

Update
SPD hosts strategic plan meeting
The city of Sedona will hold a public meeting for residents and the local business community to give feedback on community expectations of the Sedona Police Department as part of the development of its strategic plan, on Thursday, April 16, from 6:30 to 8 p.m. in the Council Chambers, located 102 Roadrunner Drive. The SPD recently began the process of developing a strategic plan that will include a vision and goals for the department and a road map. The meeting will be led by consultants from the Center for Public Safety Management. Input from this meeting will contribute to a draft plan which will be presented to the City Council this summer. For more information, contact SPD Cmdr. Heather Penner at hpenner@sedonaaz.gov or (928) 203-5160.

Why Now

The decision to bring in an outside firm follows the City Council's approval last fiscal year of nine new sworn officer positions, an emergency management coordinator and a part-time records clerk — a total of 10.5 positions. Foley said six or seven of those sworn positions remain unfilled, with two officers currently at the police academy. A third was sent to training but resigned on the first day.

“It just wasn't the right time for him,” Foley said.

She added that filling sworn positions takes longer than most hiring processes: Officers must clear an extensive background check, complete academy training and undergo field training with the department before working independently.

“It almost takes a full year to actually get them on their own,” she said.

The department is not requesting additions to its budget. Foley said the priority is filling the posts that have already been authorized before going back to the council for any additional new requests.

“This year, we're not really putting a lot in for the budget, because we still have open positions we need to fill,” she said. “This is more of a ‘get everything done’ that we've asked for, get everything up to where it is and then next year, if there was something later, we can go back to it. I think it's just a good pause here, in a sense.”

She described the current moment as a window of relative stability after a period of change — one that made bringing in outside eyes both practical and valuable.

“I think we've gotten through some hard times over the last couple of years,” Foley said. “It's leveling out. And we just had council approve nine more sworn positions.”

“We’ve made some real adjustments internally to our structure. We’re bringing on new programs. We have a lot of things, in my opinion, set up for us to be successful.”

“Sedona Police Department, with sworn and professional staff is not solely measured on permanent population,” Foley wrote in a later statement.

“There are many factors to consider when determining our staffing levels, such as calls for service, time spent on a call for service, type of call, response time, report writing and evidence packaging, and special events. Sedona’s population is made up of permanent population along with visitors both being tourists and daytime employees in the city. As many are aware, the police department operates 24/7. Meaning not all 39 allotted officers are working at one time, this covers seven days a week and 24 hours a day. During last year’s budget process an extensive presentation was given to council outlining four different studies to help determine adequate staffing levels used for public safety and specifically here in the city of Sedona.”

The Consultant

CPSM was selected after City Manager Anette Spickard reached out to agencies that had previously undergone similar reviews, rather than simply posting a public solicitation. Four firms were ultimately considered. Foley and Spickard reviewed them together before presenting two finalists to a group that included Cmdrs. Chris Dowell and Heather Penner, who helped make the final selection.

The contract was handled by Spickard and did not require a council vote as the \$37,500 contract is below the city manager’s discretionary spending authority.

Foley said one factor stood above others: Whether the consultants had worked with law enforcement.

“Having not to take on people that are maybe more business, corporate minded — having a better sense of how a police department culture can be and having worked in it, was really important to me, so that we didn’t have

issues where workshops were tough to communicate in because there's just not a connection," she said.

She also wanted a firm with experience specifically in Arizona and the West Coast, noting that policing culture can differ significantly by region.

"I remember seeing at least three departments in Arizona that they had worked with and that was important to me," Foley said. "Knowing that they've been here, that travel wouldn't be an issue and that they understand Arizona agencies — those were all pros."

CPSM worked with Maricopa County, Pinal County, El Mirage and Yuma.

She said she was also concerned about the process dragging on. Having consultants with people based nearby helped address that.

"The main thing for me is I don't want this to drag on forever for the department," she said. "We have gone through a lot and I think this is a benefit, but I would like it to be well timed."

Assessment

Foley outlined areas she hopes the consultants will evaluate, framing it as an opportunity to have experts confirm what is working and identify adjustments.

"Potentially with our calls for service, our response times and just how Sedona's growing in popularity, she said. "Are we actually staffed to where we need to be? I think that is super important.

"What I'm hoping is that with everything we've compiled to show that we minimally needed to add nine more officers before I go and think that I need more — am I on the right path from the data that I'm seeing?"

"Maybe they're saying, 'No, actually, on the day shifts you need to add two more, but your night shift is properly staffed,'" she said. "Really getting into service needs."

SPD's traffic unit is another area she wants examined. Three officers have now completed motorcycle training and a commercial vehicle inspector has been identified, though that officer has not yet completed training. A motor supervisor has not yet been selected.

"Traffic has been an ongoing complaint as long as I've been here," Foley said. "It seems appropriate to have a designated group that deals with traffic, letting the others — the patrol officers — deal with regular calls for service."

Training is also on the table. Foley said the department currently builds a training calendar on an annual basis and has lists as priorities high-liability training and report writing. But she said the consultants might come back with a recommendation she hasn't yet considered.

"Potentially, what I could imagine is somebody saying, 'No, you need a dedicated person and position that deals only with training,'" she said. "I'd like somebody to look at all of it."

SPD already works with a policy support law firm, Edwards & Amato, and the city's legal staff. But Foley said having an outside firm compare Sedona's policies against peer agencies across Arizona and the West could suggest other adjustments.

"They might say, 'Hey, we think you need to look at this policy and adjust it ... three other policies that you might want to utilize instead that we've seen,'" she said. "They'll look at our policy, they'll look at our shift coverage, they'll look at our span of control of supervisors to staff ... that's why it's, in my opinion, awesome — because this is actually what they're expert in. Having the time to do it and focus, to really go through it all holistically and then give us a lot of feedback."

Succession Planning

"Succession" is also a goal. Foley said SPD needs to prepare staff for internal advancement, rather than scrambling when a vacancy opens.

“I’m not going to stay in this profession forever,” she said. “The commanders aren’t. I think the natural thing is for people internally to see a path of growth and prepare them now.”

Many of the senior commanders — Dowell, Kwitkin and Penner — were hired from outside SPD, from Cottonwood, Boca Raton, Florida, and Tempe respectively, as were former Police Chiefs Ray Cota, David McGill and Charles Husted, who were hired from Corona, Newport Beach and Sacramento, California, respectively.

“I don’t think we’ve been the best at looking for internal promotions and really helping people get to a point where they feel comfortable going into those positions,” Foley said. “I think it makes sense for us to really get our people ready now, rather than waiting until there’s an opening and going, ‘Gosh, who wants to put in?’ Let’s start working with you now to get ready.”

Foley said she hopes to build pathways for officers toward sergeant, lieutenant and commander — and helping longtime employees prepare for life after SPD.

“If some people are going to be happy with their 20 or 25 years, how to help them also be ready for life after the police department — I think it’s just all inclusive of growth in general,” she said.

As for her own timeline, Foley — who reached 20 years as a sword officer in August and 21 years with the city in January, counting her time as a dispatcher — said she is not announcing any departure.

“I do not have a time where I’m already thinking that I’m retiring,” she said. “I mean, I will retire, yes, but I think it’s just natural to start planning now.”

Spickard said that Foley has voiced no plans to leave the chief’s position and has plans for projects over the next three years.

Confidentiality

Participation in surveys and focus groups will not be mandatory, though Foley said she hopes every SPD employee participates. She said she has asked the consulting firm to keep all individual responses anonymous — and that neither she nor Spickard will see any raw feedback. The two will receive only summaries.

“I don’t think needing to know who says what is what’s valuable here,” Foley said. “I think knowing how people feel, based on what level they’re at in their day-to-day interactions, is most important. If what is trying to be accomplished is true growth, then I think you should expect some things that won’t be great to hear. I don’t need to know who they’re from. I think it’s more beneficial just to have the information; figure out how to go forward best.”

She said she views that anonymity as the primary protection for employees who may want to speak candidly.

“I don’t want to see any of the raw information,” Foley said. “I don’t plan to see any of that. Annette won’t see any of it. That’s for the people that are in the assessment to go through and just provide a high-level overview.

“The protection that’s most important is that there’s space and freedom to say what needs to be said from their point of view.”

What’s Next

The final report is expected within three months, Spickard and Foley both said. Some recommendations may be implemented immediately, Foley said, others that require additional budget requests or more complex planning will be phased in pending council or city manager approval.

Foley said she hopes the plan becomes a working document rather than a one-time exercise.

“I hope any plan that involves strategic planning and succession planning gets reviewed again,” she said. “What was good this year might be adjusted by a lot of things, so I typically do annual retreats for our leadership team,” and continuing reviews would be part of that retreat.

Final authority over approving the plan rests with Spickard.

“I’m just really excited for this,” Foley said. “I think this is a great opportunity — that Annette’s supporting — to bring in an outside consultant to really look and give us an assessment and help with succession planning and strategic planning.”

“Are we on the right path? Are we going internally in the right direction, or do we need to make adjustments?” she asked. “This is their wheelhouse. This is what they’re good at.”

Center for Public Safety Management Contract

Loading...

Recent issues facing the Sedona Police Department

The new Strategic Plan process comes after nearly two years of issues affecting SPD.

A former dispatcher, patrol officer and K-9 officer Foley was promoted to deputy chief by Police Chief Charles Husted in July 2021. She was promoted to police chief in August 2022.

Foley hired Ryan Kwitkin, from Boca Raton, Florida, as deputy chief in May 2023. [In March 2024, Kwitkin and two staffers, Sgt. Laura Leon and administrative assistant Sheri O'Connor, filed complaints of a hostile workplace](#) against Foley, who was investigated by an outside firm. The firm [found eight allegations made against her were unsubstantiated](#), but that communication within SPD was a problem.

Deputy Chief Ryan Kwitkin

Two of those staffers who filed complaints have since left the department: Laura Olson [formerly Leon] retired, and O'Conner left and now works for the town of Clarkdale, first in the Finance Department and now with the Clarkdale Police Department.

Investigators recommended that Kwitkin, the third staffer, who was still on new-hire probation, **be investigated separately based on interviews with other officers. The city's Human Resources Manager, Russ Martin, interviewed 14 staffers regarding 13 allegations against Kwitkin**, 10 of which were substantiated, another of which was partially sustained and two of which were unsubstantiated.

Allegations Summary

The following outlines the allegations made against Deputy Chief Kwitkin during the April 2024 Police Chief investigations. These issues were conveyed by 11 of the 23¹ employees interviewed.

Date	Issue/Allegation
October 2023	Kwitkin acted aggressively during a call for service at a Police Department Volunteer's home. [REDACTED]
November 2023	Kwitkin acted aggressively to a Police Department Volunteer during a meeting of the Tech Core Committee regarding the vehicle keyboard. [REDACTED]
January 2024	Kwitkin made a request for the K-9 Officer to use the dog to search his home, for personal use, because he suspected that his adult child had drugs on the premise. [REDACTED]
February 2024	Kwitkin made a female office uncomfortable during a meeting with her in the Report Writing Room, when he locked the door and blocked egress from the room. [REDACTED]
March 2024	Kwitkin disclosed confidential information about the 2023 Lieutenant search and selection in the presence of Leon during a meeting with Human Resources on March 14, 2024.
March 2024	Kwitkin recruited Leon and O'Connor to file complaints against Foley. Attempted to leverage Leon's 2022 IA as cover for his allegations against Foley. Discussed the complaint with Leon and O'Connor after it was filed.
April 2024	Kwitkin acted unprofessionally in front of members of the public, at the high school, regarding a personal matter while in his uniform.

City of Sedona does not currently have a policy that prohibits the use of City resources for personal use and engaging in personal contact which resulted in misuse of taxpayer's taxes. However, there is evidence that Kwitkin gave Police Department work to his wife, who works for the City Manager, on more than one occasion.

Kwitkin was subsequently terminated by a deputy city manager. Kwitkin filed a wrongful termination lawsuit in Yavapai County Superior Court against Foley, Spickard, Martin and former Sedona City Manager Karen Osburn. He did not file against the deputy city manager who actually terminated him. Notably, the lawsuit alleges Martin had no experience investigating police conduct, but makes to mention of Martin's past job as Camp Verde town manager, during which time, he investigated and terminated the then-Camp Verde marshal, Nancy Gardner, for creating low morale and possible misconduct.

Kwitkin has employed at least three different law firms in the case, but his most recent lawyer, Troy Foster, died Dec. 13. Foster's associate attorney, Milca Altamirano, filed a motion to withdraw the firm from the case on Feb. 18, granted Feb. 20. Kwitkin is now representing himself without a lawyer.

Kwitkin's civil rights lawsuit in federal court **has been systematically dismantled by the courts in pretrial motions**, most recently on March 9, which dismissed due process and liability claims against the city. **The Ninth Circuit Court of Appeals agreed Tuesday, March 17, to hear the city's motion to dismiss** the last remaining claim of a free speech violation.

Mayor renews complaints against SPD, leading to his own resignation

In July 2025, **Foley filed a 157-page complaint against Scott Jablow**, Sedona's mayor, alleging "constant and continuous scrutiny, micromanagement and undermining of her position of authority" and **he filed a counter-complaint**.

An outside investigator determined **one of Foley's four allegations was substantiated, two were partially substantiated and one was not substantiated**. Four of the Jablow's allegations were not substantiated and a fifth allegation was "not applicable" because it involved the former city manager, not the chief.

Jablow was publicly censured in early September by Sedona City Council — **his third censure — over his failed efforts to unilaterally remove the chief and for acting outside the authority of the mayor's office**.

Jablow resigned at the end of September, ending his 35-month term, **notably before the final investigation into his conduct was released to the public**, however Sedona City Council unanimously voted to release the findings of the investigation and the reasons for the censures despite Jablow's resignation. Jablow has repeated his claims and Kwitkin's claims about Foley's leadership on local social media and obscure law enforcement-related blogs, like "**Law Enforcement Today**," a far-right blog of mixed credibility noted for publishing Qanon conspiracy content and fake stories about the origin of the

2020 Oregon wildfires. Many of the specific internal personnel incidents that Jablow complains about were and are identical to Kwitkin's initial claims, **which were all found to be unsubstantiated.**

During that period, Kwitkin was hired by the city of Vail, Colorado, **but his biography on the town's omits any mention of his time as Sedona deputy police chief or working for the Sedona Police Department in any capacity:**

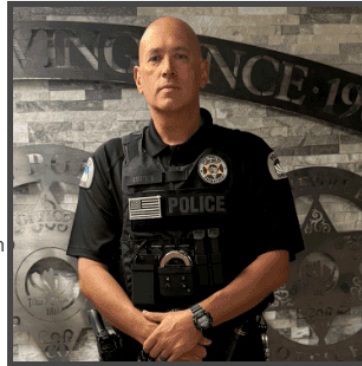
Ryan Kwitkin

Town of Vail Investigations Commander

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Commander Ryan Kwitkin began his career in law enforcement in 1999, with the Boca Raton (FL) Police Department. During that time, he worked as a patrol officer, field training officer, sergeant, tactical team sergeant, and patrol lieutenant. He retired after 24 years of service in 2023. Commander Kwitkin is looking forward to spending time with his family and 2 Labrador retrievers, exploring all the wonderful aspects that living in Colorado has to offer.



Sedona city staff report that they are unaware if they if any city staffer was contacted to by the Town of Vail to verify Kwitkin's employment history. When asked about the omission and how Kwitkin was hired, Vail Town Manager Russell Forrest wrote in an email, "Mr. Graham, Mr. Kwitkin no longer works for the Town of Vail."

Vail Town Council members declined to comment and Forrest, the town manager, provided no further comment about Kwitkin's employment or departure.

Kwitkin has also emailed the *Sedona Red Rock News* **more than 50 times** since his termination repeating allegations, and making new claims and new complaints of misconduct against Foley, SPD officers and management, city staffers and leaders, the outside investigative agency and the internal city investigators.

Editor's Note

- A shorter version of this story was published in the Friday, March 20, edition of the Sedona Red Rock News.
- The city of Sedona announced the Thursday, April 16, public meeting to discuss the strategic plan on Wednesday, April 8. See the blue box in the story above for details.

Christopher Fox Graham

Christopher Fox Graham is the managing editor of the Sedona Rock Rock News, The Camp Verde Journal and the Cottonwood Journal Extra. Hired by Larson Newspapers as a copy editor in 2004, he became assistant manager editor in October 2009 and managing editor in August 2013. Graham has won awards for editorials, investigative news reporting, headline writing, page design and community service from the Arizona Newspapers Association. Graham has also been a guest contributor in Editor & Publisher magazine and featured in the LA Times, New York Post and San Francisco Chronicle. He lectures on journalism, media law and the First Amendment and is a nationally recognized performance aka slam poet. In January 2025, the International Astronomical Union formally named asteroid 29722 Chrisgraham (1999 AQ23) in his honor at the behest of Lowell Observatory, citing him as "an American journalist and longtime managing editor of Sedona Red Rock News. He is a nationally-recognized slam poet who has written and performed multiple poems about Pluto and other space themes."



